

THE GEORGE DOUGLAS PAPERS

A family reading edition

Volume I

Reading guide and church papers

An independent reading in plain English

Prepared for Volney Douglas

September 2026

Read from the scanned originals. Uncertain words and damaged passages are marked in brackets.

Reading guide

This edition turns the English handwriting and older prose in the George Douglas scans into readable modern English. It is intended for family reading and comparison with a second independent reading. It is not a word-for-word transcription or a new historical account.

All 387 pages in the six primary PDFs in the iCloud George Douglas folder are accounted for, including archive covers, identifying slips, blank or damaged pages, and repeated documents. The separate 25-page transcription PDF is not included as a primary source. The finding aid describes additional archival folders, including a daybook and other correspondence, that are not among these six local PDFs; their manuscripts are outside this edition.

The four volumes contain: I, the collection guide, sermon notes, and church endorsement; II, Folder 1 correspondence and loan papers; III, Folder 2 correspondence and legal papers; and IV, Folder 3 correspondence and legal papers. Each volume can be read on its own. The PDFs are ready to share; the Word versions allow family corrections and comments.

How to read the text

Letters retain their first-person voice. Spelling, punctuation, abbreviations, and sentence structure have been modernized. A descriptive heading gives the writer, subject, and date when recoverable. Legal documents retain the principal parties, terms, amounts, dates, and recoverable land descriptions; repetitive formal language is simplified. Poems are given readable punctuation and, where necessary, a plain-English rendering.

Square brackets distinguish editorial explanations, damaged passages, and uncertain readings from the original writer's words. A name followed by a question mark is tentative. “Unclear,” “illegible,” “faded,” or “missing” means that this edition does not claim to recover the words. A smoothly written sentence is still an interpretation of handwriting, not a guarantee that every word has been read correctly. Particularly faded letters contain substantial gaps.

A later handwritten identifying slip is not treated as the original letter. Where a slip, filename, finding aid, or duplicate disagrees with the manuscript, the disagreement is recorded rather than silently resolved. Dates and names have not been standardized to fit a family tree. Original units such as varas remain in land descriptions. Money and acreage have not been converted into present-day equivalents.

Wartime news, diagnoses, accusations, and reports of deaths are the writers' accounts, often based on rumor. They are not findings independently established by this edition. The letters also contain the writers' views about slavery, race, religion, and the war. Those views belong to the documents; explanatory brackets identify context where needed.

Finding the original

“Scan pages” always means the page count in the source PDF, including its archive cover as page 1. It does not mean a handwritten page number or the page number at the bottom of this new edition. Every document heading names its source and scan range. Entries follow scan order, except that the text within a multi-page letter is sometimes put into readable sequence; notes describe evident rearrangements.

The table of contents links to each entry in Word and PDF. PDF bookmarks and Word's Navigation pane also provide headings. Search for a date, surname, or scan range to move directly to a passage. Source filenames and coverage are listed in Volume I and in the included source ledger.

Independence and comparison

These readings were made from the scanned manuscript images, without consulting the other agent's work. During the initial inventory, before the request for an independent version, part of the existing 25-page transcription PDF was viewed. It was then excluded and was not used further. This is therefore an independent reading in execution, but it is not a blind comparison.

Compare substantive differences against the scan: names, dates, relationships, amounts, negations, and statements about deaths matter more than wording choices in modernization. Retain both alternatives until the manuscript supports one. The most difficult passages are flagged in the text; in Folder 3, scan pages 62-67, 85-87, 100-104, 113-118 deserve particular attention. Some gaps may require a clearer photograph of the archival original.

Prepared for Volney Douglas, September 2026. The source PDFs have been left unchanged. No documents have been sent to family or to the archive.

Source files

ACU CRS MS5 - 01 - Finding Aid, George Douglas Papers 1830-1939.pdf

6 scan pages

ACU CRS MS5 - 02 - L. Douglas Sermon Notes, 16 Feb 1883.pdf

4 scan pages

ACU CRS MS5 - 03 - Sylvana Church Endorsement for George Douglas, Sept 1888.pdf

5 scan pages

ACU CRS MS5 - 04 - Folder 1, Correspondence and Loan Papers.pdf

96 scan pages

ACU CRS MS5 - 05 - Folder 2, Correspondence and Legal Papers.pdf

158 scan pages

ACU CRS MS5 - 06 - Folder 3, Correspondence and Legal Papers.pdf

118 scan pages

Total: 387 primary-source scan pages. The existing transcription PDF is excluded.

Contents

Entries are arranged by source scan page. Select an entry to open it. The page numbers below refer to the original scan, not this edition.

- Collection finding aid · 1–2 | Title and archive identification
- Collection finding aid · 3 | What the archive holds
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SOURCE 01 • COLLECTION FINDING AID • SCAN PAGES 1-2

Title and archive identification

George Douglas Papers, 1830-1939. Center for Restoration Studies, Manuscripts No. 5. Abilene Christian University Special Collections and Archives, Brown Library, Abilene Christian University, Abilene, Texas 79699-9208.

The finding aid is dated January 16, 2019. Its Digital Commons cover places the collection under Digitized Manuscripts, Personal Papers and Archival Records. The subject areas listed are Christianity, genealogy, military history, social history, and United States history. The collection address printed on the cover is https://digitalcommons.acu.edu/george_douglas.

Suggested source credit: [Identification of item], [file or folder name], George Douglas Papers, 1830-1939, Center for Restoration Studies MS #5, Abilene Christian University Special Collections and Archives, Brown Library, Abilene Christian University, Abilene, Texas.

SOURCE 01 • COLLECTION FINDING AID • SCAN PAGE 3

What the archive holds

The creator is George Douglas. The collection occupies one linear foot in two boxes and is identified as Center for Restoration Studies Manuscripts No. 5. Its inclusive and bulk dates are both given as 1830-1939. The language is English.

The collection contains photocopies of documents belonging to George Douglas, including a Civil War journal describing the battle of Sabine Pass, Texas; a Texas governor's land grant certificate; and two photographs of Douglas. It also includes copies of Nathaniel Lynn Douglas's daybook beginning in 1830, Douglas family loan and legal papers, and correspondence among family members. George Douglas served in the Confederate Army during the Civil War.

The source and date of acquisition are unknown. The accession number is R 2007.45. David Sessions and Julia Reid accessioned the collection on May 18, 2007. David Sessions, Julia Reid, and Audrey Schaffner processed it on January 29, 2014. Audrey Schaffner and Mac Ice created the finding aid on January 30, 2014; Mac Ice and Amanda Dietz updated it on January 16, 2019.

[This describes the archival collection as a whole. Not every item listed is present in the six primary PDFs supplied here.]

SOURCE 01 • COLLECTION FINDING AID • SCAN PAGE 4

Access, use, and arrangement

The finding aid says the collection has been processed and is housed in ACU Special Collections and Archives at Brown Library in Abilene. Materials do not circulate. Access is available during normal business hours, with appointments preferred.

The aid states that permission to publish, quote, or reproduce items must be secured from the repository and copyright holder. Unless rights have been transferred in writing to ACU, copyright remains with the authors or their descendants under U.S. copyright law. Researchers are responsible for their use of

the materials. [These are the archive's statements as printed in the 2019 finding aid, not an independent assessment of the present rights in any particular document.]

The documents are arranged numerically in seven folders, with letters, legal documents, loan papers, journals, daybooks, and other writings in no particular order within each folder. No materials are listed as separated from the collection.

The subject index begins with: Rebecca Alexander; James Bass; Emma Bell; George Bell; J. M. Bell; J. N. Bell; Sue Bell; Emily Douglas; Gail Douglas; George Douglas; Henry Douglas; Jess Douglas; Laura Douglas; Lizzie Douglas; Mary Douglas; N. L. Douglas; and Sarah Douglas.

SOURCE 01 • COLLECTION FINDING AID • SCAN PAGES 5–6

Subject index and folder inventory

The remaining indexed names are Warren Douglas; L. Columbia Goodloe; M. E. Goodloe; Rebecca Goodloe; Lizzie Graves; Sarah Headrick; L. A. Jettson; L. H. Jettson; Maybel Jettson; J. D. Orr; Miriam Stevenson; N. B. Winneford; and Rebecca Winneford. Other subject terms are correspondence, ephemera, and manuscripts. [Names here retain the finding aid's spellings.]

The first folder contains the finding aid.

Folder 1: correspondence and loan papers. Copies of numerous letters within the Douglas family, and loan papers dated 1939.

Folders 2 and 3: correspondence and legal papers. The inventory lists an 1887 land deed and an 1891 warranty deed; L. A. Jettson's letters to Lizzie Douglas of March 20, 1883, March 3, 1878, and February 1, 1874; Maybel Jettson to Lizzie, April 8, 1874; L. Columbia Goodloe to Lizzie, January 21, 1874; and Lizzie Graves to Lizzie Douglas, two undated letters and letters dated March 10, 1867, September 16, 1868, September 30, 1867, August 28, 1867, May 10, 1867, and November 20, 1868.

Also listed are M. E. Goodloe to Lizzie Douglas, February 12, 1865; Civil War letters from Lizzie and Laura to George; Sue Bell and Lizzie to George, August 19, 1864; Laura to George, one undated and one dated February 1, 1865; and Lizzie to George, three undated letters plus April 21, 1865, April 14, 1864, November 13, 1864, February 19, 1864, June 28, 1864, April 30, 1864, September 6, 1864, and August 5, 1864.

Legal papers include promissory notes, warranty deeds, powers of attorney, an 1874 inventory of N. L. Douglas's land, tax documents, and correspondence concerning Rebecca Alexander's inheritance.

The inventory continues with Henry Douglas to N. L. Douglas, January 12, 1855; Henry to Mary Douglas, April 8, 1853; James Bass to N. L., April 18, 1854; a poem by George Douglas dated 1867 and other poems; two letters from Sarah Gail Douglas Headrick to Lizzie, one dated 1893; one unidentified letter; and two letter fragments, one mentioning Lizzie and Laura and one mentioning George's death in 1923.

It also lists a Sylvana congregation endorsement for George dated 1883 in the aid, L. Douglas's 1883 sermon notes, Sarah Douglas's essay "The Beauty of Culture," Emma Bell's essay "Parting from Friends," L. H. Jettson to Sue Bell of February 20, 1870, Jesse to George and Lizzie of August 30, 1869, Jesse to Sarah of June 15, 1884, and Jesse to George of November 28, 1869. [The endorsement's date is discussed with that document; the aid and scan filename disagree.]

Folder 4: correspondence. Songs by Emily Douglas; Rebecca Goodloe's letters to her daughters; Miriam Stevenson to Mary Douglas; and correspondence involving Rebecca Winneford, George, Lizzie, N. L., Mary, and Laura Douglas, J. D. Orr, J. M. Bell, and Sue Bell.

Folder 5: N. L. Douglas's daybook. The daybook concerns Murfreesboro, Tennessee, and Liberty Settlement, Red Oak, Ellis County, Texas, beginning January 4, 1830. N. L. Douglas's business correspondence is also listed.

Folder 6: correspondence. J. N. Bell to Sue Bell, undated; George Douglas to Sue, January 28, 1869; George to Lizzie, March 20, May 10, and July 10, 1864; Sue to George, undated, February 10, 1863, and May 7, 1863; J. M. Bell to George, April 2, 1864; Lizzie and Laura to George, January 11, 1864; Rebecca Winneford to George Bell, July 23, 1864, February 21, 1864, May 12, 1863, September 4, 1864, December 11, 1864, and March 5, 1864; N. B. Winneford to George Douglas, 1863; Lizzie to George, two letters with month unknown in 1863, April 15, 1863, January 22, 1863, February 10, 1863, May 7, 1863, and April 2, 1863; and Lizzie to George and Warren, January 28, 1863.

Folder 7: poems and other materials. Numerous poems by George from the 1860s and 1870s; his essay "What are social parties?"; and a copy of his personal notebook containing financial and personal records.

[Folders 4-7 are described here because they appear in the supplied finding aid. Their manuscript scans are not in the local collection provided for this edition.]

SOURCE 02 • SERMON NOTES • SCAN PAGE 1

Archive cover

[ACU Digital Commons cover: L. Douglas sermon notes, dated 16 February 1883.]

SOURCE 02 • SERMON NOTES • SCAN PAGE 2

Cover label

Sermon notes. Sylvanna Church, Brushy Creek. February 16, 1883. L. [second mark or initial uncertain] Douglas.

SOURCE 02 • SERMON NOTES • SCAN PAGES 3-4

Jesus wept

[Scan page 3]

Of all the thoughts expressed in the language of inspiration, [damaged words] its precepts and its promises, what conveys more to our minds and hearts than the short sentence, "Jesus wept"?

Let us look for a moment at the character of Jesus. Who and what is he? If we accept the truths of the Bible, he is the Son of God, the King of the Jews, the bright and morning star! A ruler of the Jews came to Jesus and said, "We know you are a teacher come from God, for no man can do the miracles that you do unless God is with him."

Look, then, at the power of this man. By his word, water is turned into wine. The blind receive their sight; the lame walk. By his word, the tempest is stilled, and he [walks on?] the waves of wild Galilee. By his word, the dead are called back to life again. “Truly he was the Son of God.”

But the Bible is not our only testimony to this man's greatness. Renan, in his *Life of Christ*, says, “All ages will proclaim that among the sons of men there were none born greater than Jesus.” His goodness, his greatness, his almighty power: we cannot doubt them. We stand in awe as we contemplate them, and our hearts acknowledge him as King of Kings and Lord of Lords.

But while we contemplate all this glorious majesty, our eyes fall on this simple sentence: “Jesus wept.” What do we learn from these two short words? We learn that he had a heart that could be touched by the sorrows and suffering of our frail humanity; that sympathy [damaged passage continues on next page]

[Scan page 4]

has the power to “make even the wretched blessed,” had its home in his breast, and that he could be touched by a feeling of our infirmities.

How our hearts thrill with love and thankfulness when we think of this blessed truth: that he sympathized with the sorrows of frail humanity.

More than eighteen hundred years have been measured by the revolving earth since Jesus walked the shores and waves of Galilee, but the influence of his words and life is still felt. Through the coming ages it will be felt until time is no more. With all the records of his wonderful life, this simple truth will pass down with the others: “Jesus wept.”

L. Douglas

Sylvanna, February 16, 1883

[Verse written below the signature]

Forever reign, victorious King;
Let your name be known throughout the earth;
And call our longing souls to sing
The highest anthems near your throne.

[Reading note: The wording after “sympathy” is damaged at the page boundary. The sentence has not been silently reconstructed. The quoted Bible passages and closing verse above are also rendered in modern English.]

SOURCE 03 • SYLVANA CHURCH ENDORSEMENT • SCAN PAGE 1

Archive cover

[ACU Digital Commons cover: Endorsement from the congregation at Sylvana Church for George Douglas, September 1888.]

SOURCE 03 • SYLVANA CHURCH ENDORSEMENT • SCAN PAGE 2

Cover label

Endorsement of the congregation for Sylvana Church. George Douglas. September 1888. Elders H. Douglas and H. [G.?] Orr.

SOURCE 03 • SYLVANA CHURCH ENDORSEMENT • SCAN PAGE 3

The congregation approves his preaching

This certifies that Brother George Douglas, a member of the Church of Christ worshiping at Sylvana, Ellis County, Texas, has for some time been working in preaching and teaching. Wishing him to continue this work, we are pleased to state that he goes with our full permission and wholehearted approval.

May he share the Apostle Paul's conviction, "Woe to me if I do not preach the Gospel of Christ," always remembering the solemn charge to Timothy to preach the word, and so forth.

SOURCE 03 • SYLVANA CHURCH ENDORSEMENT • SCAN PAGE 4

Folded sheet label

Endorsement of the Sylvana congregation.

SOURCE 03 • SYLVANA CHURCH ENDORSEMENT • SCAN PAGE 5

Date and elders

Given by order of the church on the second Lord's Day [Sunday] in September 1888.

Elders: H. Douglas; H. G. Orr.

[Reading note: The document itself gives 1888. The finding aid's inventory gives 1883 for this item.]